Pivotum

THE DEGREE RISK INDEX · FALL 2026 EDITION · FREE SAMPLER

# Is a Journalism Degree Worth It in the AI Era? The 2026 Risk Score

The free sampler — the score by track, the six factors in brief, and the honest reasons to think twice. The complete profile goes deeper.

8.3

AI EXPOSURE · DESK / AGGREGATION & REWRITE

where 10 is most at risk

Re-scored every six months. We publish where we might be wrong.

HIGHLIGHTING IS COLOUR-CODED

THE FINDING   EXPOSURE   PROTECTION   METHOD & HONESTY

> **Quick answer:** Desk journalism — aggregation, rewriting and routine news production — scores **8.3 out of 10** for AI exposure, where 10 is most at risk. Investigative reporting scores **5.1**. But journalism is the profession where our score is least useful on its own, because the industry was contracting hard for economic reasons long before AI arrived.

**The short answer for parents: not as a route to a newsroom desk job — that path is close to closed, and mostly for reasons that have nothing to do with AI.** Journalism holds up as a *skill set* — verification, sourcing, clear writing under pressure, working a beat — pointed at investigative work, specialist reporting, or paired with a domain.

## Journalism AI risk score by track

Every career in this index is scored 1–10, where **10 is most exposed** to AI. Same six factors, same weights, applied identically to a reporter and a paramedic.

| TRACK | 2023 | 2025 | FALL 2026 | 3-YR MOVE | BAND |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Investigative reporting | 4.5 | 4.8 | **5.1** | +0.6 | Moderate |
| Specialist / trade reporting | 5.2 | 5.5 | **5.8** | +0.6 | Moderate |
| Data journalism | 5.7 | 6.1 | **6.5** | +0.8 | Moderate–High |
| General news reporting | 6.0 | 6.4 | **6.7** | +0.7 | Moderate–High |
| Desk / aggregation & rewrite | 7.0 | 7.8 | **8.3** | +1.3 | High |

*2023 and 2025 figures are reconstructed using current methodology, not archived from past editions.*

**How that compares:** the median career in this edition scores around 5.5. Graphic design production scores **8.4.** Entry-level software development scores **8.1.** Bedside nursing scores **2.8.**

**Note the starting point.** Desk journalism was already at 7.0 in 2023 — the highest 2023 score of any track in this index. Its problem substantially predates AI, and the score reflects a profession that had already been squeezed for two decades.

## Will AI replace journalists?

It has largely absorbed the desk layer and barely touched original reporting.

| AI IS TAKING | IT CAN'T TOUCH |
|---|---|
| Rewriting wire copy | Being in the room |
| Aggregating other outlets' coverage | Cultivating a source who trusts you |
| Summarizing reports and filings | Getting a document nobody published |
| Routine sports and earnings write-ups | Standing behind a claim legally |
| Headline and SEO optimization | Judgment about what matters and why |
| Transcription and first-pass editing | Knowing when someone is lying to you |

Adoption among working journalists is now near-universal. That is not the same as displacement — most news executives report AI has not reduced headcount, and the disruption is landing on required skills more than on job numbers.

## Why the score is misleading on its own

This is the profession where we most want to say: **read the number carefully.**

Employment in American publishing has fallen roughly 40% since the late 1990s, from around 91,000 jobs to about 55,000. Newsroom cuts have run into the thousands annually for years. That collapse was driven by classified revenue moving to the platforms, advertising moving to search and social, and audiences fragmenting — not by automation.

Our index measures automation exposure. It does not measure industry health, and journalism is the clearest case where those two things come apart.

So the honest reading is: **the economics are the primary risk, and AI is the accelerant.** The desk job was the shock absorber — the role that survived earlier rounds because someone had to rewrite the wire copy. That is the part now automating, which removes the remaining cushion from an industry that had already used up its slack.

A student should weigh the industry's finances first and our score second. We would rather say that plainly than claim more for our own factor than it deserves.

## Why does desk journalism score so high? The six factors

How desk and aggregation work rates against each. Ratings are 0–10 on each factor's own terms.

| FACTOR | RATING | EFFECT ON RISK |
|---|---|---|
| How much of this job can AI already do? | 8.6 | ↑ severe exposure |
| How hard will it be to land that first job? | 8.5 | ↑ severe exposure |
| Does it have to be done in person, with your hands? | 1.0 | ↓ none |
| Does someone need a human they can trust and hold responsible? | 3.0 | ↓ almost none |
| Does the law require a licensed human? | 1.0 | ↓ none |
| How often does the job hit genuinely new, high-stakes situations? | 3.0 | ↓ almost none |

### ONE FACTOR, WORKED THROUGH IN FULL

*So you can see what the analysis actually looks like.*

**How hard will it be to land that first job? — rated 8.5, and it was already broken before AI**

Across this index, entry-path erosion is usually a recent story: AI absorbs the junior tasks, and the on-ramp narrows over three or four years. Journalism is the exception, and it is instructive.

**The traditional apprenticeship — local paper, desk shifts, learning the craft on small stories before working up to bigger ones — had already thinned dramatically before generative AI existed.** Local titles closed. Regional newsrooms consolidated. Entry-level reporting jobs disappeared with the revenue that funded them.

So when we rate journalism 8.5 on this factor, most of that rating is not about automation. It is about an industry that spent twenty years removing the rungs for economic reasons, and has now automated what remained of them.

**This matters for how a family should read the score.** In nursing, the entry-path rating of 2.0 tells you something durable — clinical hours are mandated by law and will not disappear. In journalism, the 8.5 reflects a combination of forces, only one of which our framework measures, and the non-AI part is both larger and less likely to reverse.

**The general lesson: when a factor rates badly, ask what is actually driving it.** Automation-driven erosion might reverse if firms rediscover the value of training juniors. Economics-driven erosion does not reverse unless the money comes back.

Worth knowing: hiring has migrated rather than vanished. Subscription outlets, specialist and trade publications, and nonprofit local newsrooms are where the roles now sit — and the profession is generating new categories that did not exist a decade ago, including editorial engineering and AI-innovation roles at major titles.

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## Which journalism careers are safest from AI?

Ranked by exposure, safest first:

1. **Investigative reporting — 5.1.** Sources, documents, physical presence and legal accountability for what you publish. 2. **Specialist / trade reporting — 5.8.** Deep domain knowledge in a field where scarcity still exists. 3. **Data journalism — 6.5.** Technical skill plus editorial judgment, though the analysis layer is automating. 4. **General news reporting — 6.7.** Real reporting, but with substantial routine production content. 5. **Desk / aggregation — 8.3.** Largely automated, and the traditional entry point.

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## Is a journalism degree still worth it in 2026?

As preparation for a newsroom desk job, no — and honest programs will say so.

As a skill set, it holds up better than the headline number suggests. Verification, sourcing, interviewing, working a beat and writing clearly under pressure are genuinely valuable and increasingly scarce, particularly as the volume of unverified content rises.

The versions that work point somewhere specific: investigative work, a specialist beat in a complex field, or journalism paired with a domain — data, science, finance, health — where the combination is rarer than either half.

The question worth asking any program: where are your graduates actually employed, and is the curriculum built around original reporting or content production? **The first is a career. The second is the automated part.**

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## Common questions

**Will AI replace journalists?** It has largely absorbed rewriting, aggregation and routine production. Original reporting — sources, documents, being present — is barely touched.

**Is journalism a dying career?** The industry has been contracting for twenty-five years for economic reasons. AI is the newest pressure, not the decisive one. That distinction matters for anyone deciding.

**What journalism jobs are safest from AI?** Investigative reporting at 5.1, then specialist and trade reporting at 5.8. Both depend on human relationships and original material rather than on processing existing text.

**Is a journalism degree useless?** No — but its value now depends on where it points. As general preparation for newsroom employment it is weak; as training in verification and reporting aimed at a specialty it holds up.

**Should my child study journalism or something else?** If the pull is genuine, the defensible version is journalism plus a domain. If the pull is writing rather than reporting specifically, worth reading our marketing and content profiles alongside this one, since those score worse.

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## Related profiles

- **Graphic & visual design** — 8.4 production, 5.6 creative direction
- **Marketing & communications** — 8.2 content execution, 5.5 brand strategy
- **Law** — 7.9 junior associate, 4.5 trial advocacy
- **Computer science** — 8.1 entry-level, 5.4 senior. Free to read in full.
- **Data science & analytics** — coming in this edition

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## What's in the full journalism profile

This sampler tells you where journalism stands. The full profile tells you what to do about it.

| | SAMPLER | FULL PROFILE |
|---|---|---|
| Verdict, all track scores, 3-year trend | ✓ | ✓ |
| Six-factor ratings | ✓ | ✓ |
| **Reasoning behind every factor rating** | one example | ✓ |
| **How durable each protection is** | | ✓ |
| **The industry economics in full** — and how to weigh them against the score | | ✓ |
| **The honest downsides** — pay, precarity, and where hiring has actually moved | | ✓ |
| **What's genuinely good about it** — and who this work suits | | ✓ |
| **The AI-native advantage** — how to prepare, and why this cohort has an opening | | ✓ |
| **The new roles** — editorial engineering, AI innovation, verification | | ✓ |
| **Domain pairings that work** | | ✓ |
| **Program evaluation checklist** — original reporting versus content production | | ✓ |
| **Questions to ask a program** — plus red flags | | ✓ |
| **Sourced further reading** | | ✓ |
| **Discussion questions** for parent and student | | ✓ |
| **A short version written directly to the student** | | ✓ |
| Technical scoring appendix | | ✓ |

## GET THE FULL PROFILES

Most families are weighing two or three careers seriously, and a few more they haven't ruled out. Pick the ones you need.

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **1 profile** | **$19** | Choose → |
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| **5 profiles** | **$39** | Choose → |

Each full profile includes everything in the table above, plus a short version written directly to the student and the technical scoring appendix. Spring 2027 updates of whatever you buy are included.

**Read a complete profile free →** We publish one profile in full, openly, so you can judge the depth before buying anything. Computer science is the one to read — it's the most surprising result in the index.

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*Pivotum scores thirty careers against AI exposure using a fixed, published methodology, re-scored every six months. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed. We publish where we might be wrong.*